

Obtaining Observers for Tournaments

USA Ultimate Certified Observers are a great asset to any tournament. Observers are game officials whose job is to support the players in implementing a safe, fair, and efficient game. Observers carefully watch the action of the game, assist with communication, help uphold self-officiating and the Spirit of the Game, assist with resolving calls, and perform other duties.

In addition, observers legitimize the reputation of events, and can be a great recruiting tool for attracting more teams to a tournament.

Roles

- Regional Observer Coordinators (ROCs) oversee observers and help coordinate observer crews for tournaments in their respective regions.
- The Head Observer (HO) is the lead observer for a tournament. The HO may work with the ROC to help recruit a crew for their tournament. Once the crew is established, the HO works with the Tournament Director(s) to organize logistics and assign games.
- On larger crews, a Deputy Head Observer (DHO) may assist the HO with various duties.

Budget

The first step to securing observers for a tournament is to establish an observer budget. A healthy observer budget should include the following:

- **Payment:** Observers are paid either on a per-game basis or a flat rate.
 - Standard per-game rates are generally between \$25-40+ per game.
 - For tournaments with more than eight games, a flat rate can be used in lieu of a per-game rate. Standard flat rates are generally between \$200-300.
- **Lodging:** Observers require lodging when traveling at least one hour or 50+ miles to a tournament. Lodging should be provided for each night prior to a tournament day, but not after a tournament ends. For example, at a 2-day event on Saturday and Sunday, most observers would need lodging Friday and Saturday nights, but not Sunday night.
 - Some observers may elect to skip the first night of lodging and drive up the morning of a tournament, but this should be their choice. If a tournament runs late on the last day, consider providing lodging for that night, especially for observers facing a long drive or flight home.
 - Each observer should have their own bed (sofa-beds and couches don't count), with no more than two or three observers per room. Observers should only room with other observers or tournament staff, and only of the same gender.
 - Lodging should be of reasonable quality. Cheap locations with poor reviews should be avoided. At the same time, high-end 5-star hotels are not necessarily needed. For many cities (but not all), hotels in the \$90-120/night range suffice.
 - Comped or discounted rooms are a great way to reduce observer lodging costs. A hotel may offer these in exchange for teams booking a certain number of rooms. City tourism departments may also be able to contribute resources.
 - An Airbnb or Vrbo can be used for crews of eight or less if above criteria are met.
 - In rare cases, observers may agree to stay in homes of tournament staff to reduce costs, but this should be their choice.

- **Food:** Observers exert a significant amount of energy over the course of a tournament, and accordingly, need three meals for each tournament day.
 - Breakfast on a tournament day should be provided or reimbursed. Free breakfast at the hotel where observers are staying is a great way to save on costs.
 - Lunch on a tournament day should be provided. A popular choice for observers is footlong sub sandwiches, from Subway or similar, or from a grocery store. Head Observers can compile preferences and dietary restrictions from their crew, but event staff should order the lunches and facilitate pickup or delivery. Apps, discount codes, and loyalty programs are a great way to save on lunch costs.
 - Dinner on a tournament day should either be provided or reimbursed.
 - Meals before a tournament begins or after a tournament ends generally do not need to be provided or reimbursed.
 - Observers generally provide their own snacks and drinks. However, tournaments in warm weather should consider providing cold sports drinks or coolers with ice. While not required, this can make a big difference on observer attentiveness.
- **Travel:** Observers typically either drive or fly to tournaments. In some rare cases observers may also take a train or public transit to tournaments.
 - Observers who drive should either be reimbursed at the [IRS mileage rate](#), or reimbursed for round-trip gas (or electricity, for EVs). Observers generally try to carpool to reduce fuel costs.
 - Gas costs vary, but in general, are between \$30-100 per driver.
 - Observers located too far away to drive (generally over 4-6 hours away) may need to fly to tournaments. Observers should only be reimbursed for flights in economy class with no extra add-ons.
 - Flight costs vary, but in general, are between \$250-450 per flier.
- **Transportation:** Observers who fly need transportation to and from the airport, fields, and lodging. This is generally arranged by the Head Observer, with driving observers transporting flying observers. In some cases, if there aren't enough driving observers, or if the logistics are too extreme, rental car(s) or Uber/Lyft may need to be provided.

If budgets are tight, some of the above criteria may be reduced or eliminated to save on costs. For example, observers may choose to skip the first round or two of a tournament and drive up that morning to save on lodging costs. Tournament Directors should discuss budget constraints with Regional Observer Coordinators and Head Observers accordingly.

That being said, offering higher quality amenities or payment at a more competitive rate can yield a stronger, more motivated observer crew. This is especially important for tournaments that conflict with other tournaments on the same weekend.

Communication

Once an observer budget is established, Tournament Directors should contact the Regional Observer Coordinator corresponding to the region where their tournament is held. A list of ROCs and their emails can be found [here](#). A map of each region can be found [here](#).

In the initial email, Tournament Directors should indicate the date and location of their event, how many observers they have budgeted for, and any important budget constraints. The ROC will then recruit a Head Observer for the tournament. (Note: The ROC might also be the HO.) The ROC and/or HO will then recruit an observer crew for the tournament.

Tournament Directors should aim to contact their ROC at least three months prior to their tournament, or if less than three months are remaining, then as soon as possible. In general, the more advanced warning there is, the better. This is important both for recruiting crews as well as reducing flight and lodging costs. The TD and ROC/HO should determine who will purchase lodging, meals, and rental cars (if applicable). Observers book their own flights.

Once the tournament is a few weeks out, the Tournament Director and Head Observer should convene to confirm the observer crew, share contact information, and discuss key logistics. Key logistics include confirming field and lodging locations, explaining game format and round times, providing a field map, etc. TDs may wish to include other tournament staff on these emails, such as facility staff, team presidents, and volunteers.

Tournament

In the days preceding the tournament, the Head Observer will assign observers to games. Observers work in pairs of two for most games until semifinals and finals, when they work in groups of three or four. In a pinch, some observers may work games solo, but not by default.

The Head Observer assigns games based on several factors, including: How competitive is the game likely to be? How chippy or contentious could the game potentially become? Other factors include: Streaming schedule, diversity of teams or divisions, historic data, etc.

The Head Observer will check in with the Tournament Director the morning of each tournament day to discuss any last-minute logistics, as well as at the end, to discuss how the day went.

Compensation

After the tournament, the Tournament Director and Head Observer should convene to arrange compensation for the crew. The Head Observer can compile receipts or provide an invoice if needed. There are multiple approaches to facilitating compensation:

- Tournament staff can send a lump sum payment to the ROC or HO, who then distributes it accordingly to each observer
- Tournament staff can send each payment directly to each observer

Electronic payment via Paypal or Venmo is generally preferred, but checks can work if needed.

If you have any questions about obtaining observers, please contact the ROC in your region.